joining a political agitation at the age of 10 to defeating his political guru in an election to unseating a winning chief minister, Sarma is a past master at creating a new paradigm of power politics. In 2014, he was a Congressman campaigning against Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Today, he's often the first to take up cudgels for Modi, his police team moving at lightning speed to arrest anyone who bad-mouths the PM—be it Congress spokesperson Pawan Khera who was deplaned last month or Gujarat MLA Jignesh Mewani who was flown in from Ahmedabad in April last year.

Critics call his actions the murder of free speech; the Congress even accuses him of having a "God syndrome". When the Supreme Court released Khera on bail, Sarma was still brazen about his intent: "We hope that keeping the sanctity of public spaces, no one will use uncivilised language in political discourse hereafter." Many say he does all this to showcase his loyalty to his new masters—the BJP and the RSS—but party insiders say he has the sanction of the top two in the power hierarchy—Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah. Following Khera's arrest, when some Congress leaders chanted slogans: "*Modi teri qabar khudegi* (You're digging your grave, Modi)"—the prime minister cited the slogan in his campaign speech in Nagaland the next day saying his opponents may hope for his death, but the people will make the lotus (the BJP symbol) bloom. "If there was no approval from Modi, Sarma would not have dared to do the same thing again after the Mewani incident," says a senior BJP leader. "He has become their trusted henchman."



TARMAC TOLL Congress leaders protest Pawan Khera's arrest at the Delhi airport



"Himanta does not fight shy of calling a spade a spade. He is not bothered about political correctness, and that's his strength. He has captured the imagination of people in not just Assam but across the country"

RAM MADHAV
Member, RSS national executive



THE BACKDOOR OPERATOR

In fact, his ability to deliver without a care for political correctness has made the Assam chief minister the key person in most of Shah's backdoor political missions. From sheltering Maharashtra's rebel Shiv Sena leaders to facilitating the defection of eight Goa Congress MLAs to brokering peace between West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and then state governor (and now vice-president) Jagdeep Dhankhar, Sarma's imprint has expanded beyond the boundaries of the Northeast. In July last year, he was suspected to be behind another attempted coup—this time in Jharkhand—when Kolkata police arrested three Jharkhand Congress MLAs with Rs 49 lakh in cash in their vehicle. Police sources claim the MLAs were returning from Guwahati. The buzz was that Sarma had been planning to topple the Hemant Soren-led government in Jharkhand in which Congress is an alliance partner. "He has the money and the team to carry out such stealth operations," says a senior BJP leader.

In fact, at the core of all these "stealth operations" are his personal relationships, particularly with Congress leaders across the country. That's what helped him become the chief architect of the BJP's expansion in the Northeast. He has acted as a catalyst in the defection of Congress leaders to the BJP, and many a time they have come in droves. Rivals say he uses his money power and BJP's political clout to buy out MLAs. However, Prof. Nani Gopal Mahanta, advisor to Assam's education department and Sarma's long-time friend, reiterates that it's the personal relationships he has nurtured over the years that do the magic.

Even when he was in the Congress, Assam witnessed many such incidents. In 2010, he drove four BJP MLAs in his own car to the assembly to get them to vote for the Congress Rajya Sabha candidate. The popular joke now in the state is that Sarma runs five parties apart from the BJP—ally AGP and UPPL and ri-